

What's KDE 2.2.1 all about?

Part of a project started in 1996 to get over the shortcomings in the X11 desktop, KDE presents a user environment which is comparable to the Windows user interface. Users get almost all of the Windows features such as drag-and-drop functionality, right-click context sensitive menus, keyboard shortcuts, advanced file management features, etc. In addition, KDE has features not available in Windows such as network and development tools.

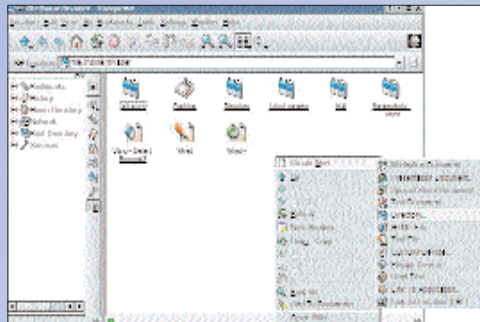
KDE 2.2.1, the latest KDE version, was released in September this year. This came just one month after the launch of KDE 2.2. Undoubtedly, the competition from other Linux desktop environments such as Gnome had a positive effect in bringing about such a fast launch. It comes in 42 languages with the core KDE libraries and desktop environment.

Major highlights of the KDE bandwagon are Konqueror and the KOffice suite. Konqueror is an advanced file manager for KDE which offers a lot of other functionalities like acting as a viewing application or an HTML 4.0 compliant Web browser with support for Java applets, JavaScript and CSS1, and partial support for CSS2. Netscape plug ins like Flash and RealVideo also run on Konqueror.

The KOffice suite has a word processor (KWord), spreadsheet (KSpread), presentation application (KPresenter), flowcharting application (Kivio), drawing application (Kontour), image editor (Krayon), business report generator (Kugar), and a graph and chart drawing tool (KChart).

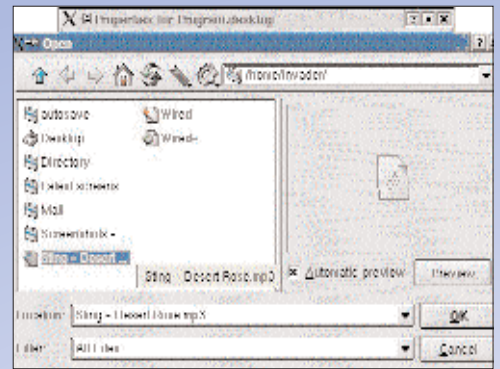
Chalking out territory

Now that we've got KDE in place, its time we explored it a bit. The best tool for this is to use Konqueror, KDE's powerful multipurpose built-in file explorer. Click on the Home Directory icon on the task bar and Konqueror will show the contents of your home directory. This is the place where most of your files will be saved. You can also use it to go to other places on the hard disk.



Right-click in the Home Directory and use the menu for creating new directories

Creating new files and directories in your home directory can be done easily. Just right-click in the directory where you want to create the new file or directory. This brings up the menu. Go to Create New > Directory and click on it to create the new directory. Give it a name and click OK. Your new directory will be created. Files can also be created in the same manner.



Use the Browse button to locate the files or applications for which you want to create shortcuts

Taking it easy

Want to put some new short cuts on your desktop? First get the jargon right. In KDE, shortcuts are called links.

To create a new link simply right-click on the desktop and go to Create New > Link to application. Clicking on this brings up the Properties for Program.desktop box. Give the name of the link. Now click on the Execute tab in the box. Enter the location of the file or application in the Command box if you know the path, else use the Browse button to locate the file. Click on OK and the new link is ready.

A bit of cosmetic surgery

Who doesn't want to give a personal feel to their desktop? KDE provides us with a whole range of options in the cosmetic department.

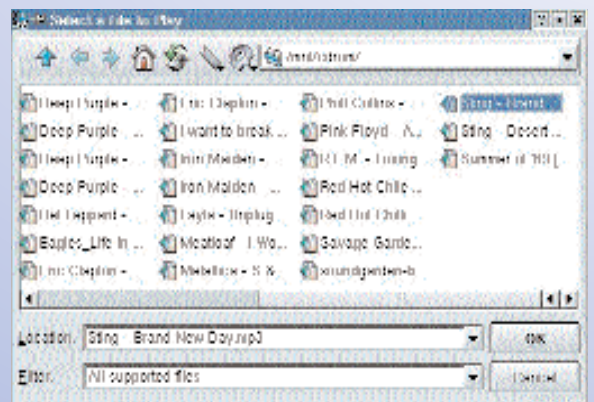
Grooving with KDE Media Player

What's life without music and movies? KDE Media Player is a companion which will help you out in this. It can play both audio and video files. The interface is somewhat basic but it gets the job done.

To start the KDE Media Player go to Multimedia > KDE Media Player in the Application Starter. Start KDE Media Player by clicking on it. Now go to File > Open to select the file you want to play. Select the file you want to open by single-clicking on it. Selecting OK will play the file.

Playing files from the CD-ROM is a bit more complicated. For this you have to go to the root directory and then to the mnt directory. Now you can view the CD-ROM contents by clicking on the cdrom icon. Select the file you want to open and click OK to open the file.

Multiple selection of files is not possible, which is a bit of a problem when playing music



files, as you have to play them one by one. But, for video files this won't be that much of a problem. It's better to use a player like the XMMS Media Player for playing music files, especially if you are a Winamp addict. XMMS comes as a standard with most Linux flavours like Red Hat and others.